

## Rule Four: Dye Everything You Can Reach

Do-yun ("Doha")

Nobody warns you about going into hiding: the hard part isn't the fear. The hard part is that within about an hour you turn into a snoop.

I'd been in the apartment forty minutes and I'd already read the whole woman off her shelves, greedily, the way you read a stranger's diary over their shoulder on the subway and tell yourself you're just resting your eyes.

I walked it once, slow. Not for the exits — I read a room the way I read a stage, which is for the person who's going to stand in it. One main room doing the job of four. Two-ring stove. A table that folds down off the wall. Two chairs that had never once, in their lives, matched. A sink at a window that looked directly into the brick flank of the next building, which is the kind of view you get for the kind of rent that lets a man like me hide here without anyone asking a single question. Somewhere below, a pipe knocked and ran; the building had a heartbeat and it wasn't a healthy one.

Everything sat square to everything else, because there was nothing spare to be out of place.

What wasn't there told me more. No photographs. None. No faces in frames, no fridge papered with the people who'd come running if she called. A row of accounting textbooks, the spines cracked white from being opened a hundred times. A ledger by the kettle with a column for everything down to, I checked, the bus fare. One mug in the rack. And a bolt — a cheap brass bolt — fitted to the inside of the bedroom door by someone who had clearly decided that the locks other people gave her were not locks she trusted.

One mug. I kept coming back to the one mug.

I've spent fifteen years in rooms that other people built to tell lies about me. Rooms staged down to the open book left face-up on the arm of a chair so the magazine could photograph it and call me bookish. This room wasn't staged. It was just a person, with no audience, accidentally telling the truth. I could've stood in it an hour.

My phone had been going off face-down on the table the entire time — the group chat, doing what the group chat does, which is never, ever stop, the screen lighting and dimming and lighting against the wood. I left it face-down. For two months, that was the whole plan. Two months to find out what my own thoughts sounded like when there wasn't somebody talking across them.

Then I went and showered in a stranger's bathroom, in a stranger's terrible hard water, and did the thing I'd been doing to myself for weeks.

You want to know how a pop star disappears? He doesn't. He box-dyes his own hair over a sink at midnight and calls it a disguise.

The silver had been the comeback look. Seungwoo's hair — the colour off the billboards, the thing a person clocks from forty feet down a platform and reaches for their phone about. So I drowned it. Cheap drugstore black, worked in with gloved fingers, because a salon is a paper trail and a stylist is a mouth with legs. The water ran grey down the drain and then ran clear, and the result, when I wiped the steam off the mirror, was a flat amateur black gone patchy at the temples, a thread of grey left at the crown where my own hand couldn't reach, and the overall effect of a man who'd let his cousin do it in a garage.

It was, I'll be honest, the best I'd looked in months. A man you wouldn't glance at twice on a train. Scrubbed face no stylist had touched in weeks. The build, the scar across the right knuckles I don't talk about. Nobody. Beautifully nobody.

Except the eyes.

The eyes were still mine. Storm-grey, no bottom to them, and there is no box dye on earth for that. I can drown the silver, scrub off Seungwoo, sign a dead-end name to a lease, and the eyes stay exactly what they were the night a girl looked into them across a convenience-store counter and, for the first time in my life, didn't try to sell me anything back.

She won't remember, I told the mirror, toweling off. She'd handed warm cans to a hundred wet strangers. She didn't carry one of them around three years later like a stone she'd forgotten was in her pocket, the way I carried —

The key turned in the front door.

A flat voice came through it. There's been a mistake. The room's taken.

I did the gentlemanly thing, which was to walk out into the hall in the only thing I had on, to explain.

The woman standing there with her keys still in her fist was —

Her.

Not someone who looked like her. Her. The girl from the rain. The warm can. The coins pushed back across a counter three years ago and never once, since, set down.

I gave the shock exactly one second, because she was looking at me the way you look at

a floor that's no longer there, and a frightened person has no use for a man who's busy being struck by lightning.

But I looked. I couldn't not. Every other time the world had handed her to me she'd been behind something — a counter three years back, an apron four nights ago in a diner she didn't know I'd walked past twice — wearing the flat service face a person puts on to survive a shift. There was none of it now. This was her doorway, her kitchen, her four walls. The rain was still in her hair. And the half-second before she saw me, before the guard came up, before tired hardened into braced — that was the realest I have ever been allowed to see her, and I'm not a good enough man to pretend I didn't keep it.

Then it went. I watched her come back online the way I've watched a hundred rooms read me, except backwards, because she wasn't reading the idol. She had no idea there was an idol to read. Her eyes left me and went around the room and snagged: the box split open on the floor, my shirts folded in it by hands I pay to fold them; the shoes paired by her door; the watch sitting out on her table like it had always lived there. I watched the sum come up behind her face and drop straight into her shoulders.

A man. A man had moved into her flat.

Her weight went back toward the door. The bag slid off her shoulder, and she let it fall, and didn't look down. The question in her wasn't who is he. It was how do I get out. And that put a stone behind my ribs that I'm fairly sure is still there, because I had already decided I would not be one more reason a woman counted the exits in her own kitchen.

"You're—" The radiator picked that exact moment to bang twice and eat the word. I started again. "Hyun said the tenant was supposed to be—" and stopped, because the end of the sentence was a man, and she was already reading the rest off my face, chin lifting to meet it: the same ambush, run from both ends.

And then the whole situation arrived for what it actually was — the two of us squared off across a floor of boxes, me in a towel, both of us robbed by the identical piece of paperwork — and I felt the corner of my mouth go before I could stop it. Bad timing has always made me cheerful. It's a character flaw.

"Well." I did not reach for the towel. I did not apologize for the towel. "You're not what the paperwork promised either."

She didn't laugh. But her eyes dropped.

Once.

They caught on a bead of water sliding down my chest — one of the grey ones, the dye still bleeding out of me — and went after it. Collarbone. The flat of the stomach. The low edge of the towel. The whole way down before she hauled them back up to safe ground

like a woman retrieving a dropped phone over a railing.

I have been looked at my entire adult life. I know the look that wants the poster. The look already drafting the text to its friends. The look pricing the jacket. Girls have gone white and shaking in front of me over a face on a screen, and not once has it touched me, because it was never me they were short of breath about.

This was not that.

She didn't know there was a poster. She'd never heard my name. The colour climbing her throat, the breath she couldn't keep level, the eyes that bolted off me and came right back — all of it was for the wet, plain, nameless man dripping on her floorboards. And it went through me slow and low and entirely animal and did the thing nothing in fifteen years had managed.

It made me feel real.

Which is the most embarrassing sentence I have ever thought, and I let the laugh out anyway — low and warm and helpless, the real one, the one I don't keep on a hook for anybody — and I left her caught, because I am, at bottom, not a nice person.

"Take your time," I said, the laugh still in it. "I don't mind being looked at."

The colour came up her throat in one tide. Neck, the tops of the ears, both cheeks — fast and total and none of it permitted — and I watched it climb with a pleasure I had no right to and took anyway.

She stepped back from it, hard. Her heel clipped a box, the floor tilted, she grabbed the frame and stayed up.

"What is all this." She threw it at the boxes. The boxes were a safer target than I was.

"Mine. Clothes, mostly." My hand went to the back of my neck and the ease went a little sheepish on me. "I hadn't unpacked. I was going to shower first." I looked down at the towel. "Obviously."

She did not laugh. I watched her decide not to laugh, which is a different and much more interesting thing, and watched the careful eye come back online the second she had a problem in her hands instead of a feeling. Quick cold inventory — of me, of the cloth, of the cost of it all stacked in a box room.

"You moved in. All of this. For two months."

The true answer had my entire life folded up inside it. I handed her the shutter instead. "Short stays suit me."

I watched her set that aside without a word and file it somewhere to be opened later.

She files things, and the file never, ever closes.

"Who are you." Not the boxes now. Me. Too loud — the fury arriving dead on schedule, a demand with the question filed off it.

"...You're Jae-wu."

It came out low and careful, set down with both hands, and I heard it land wrong the instant it was out. A stranger reads Yun Jae-wu off a contract and says Ms. Yun. A stranger does not reach straight past the surname for the given name and lay it down soft like a thing he's been keeping in his coat. I watched the cold run down her spine. I'd have taken it back if I'd had any way to. I never have, where she's concerned.

"How do you know my name?"

"It's on the lease." Easy enough. True enough. My eyes cut a hair sideways before I could stop them, and I knew she caught it. She catches everything.

"You're Hyun?"

"Hyun works for me. I'm—" half a breath's hitch, choosing out of a drawer of names that all belong to other men. "Doha."

I watched her take the name and find it sealed shut. A plain envelope with nothing written on it. And while she worked at it, I got to watch her, which was its own small disaster. Because the careful woman fidgeted. The thumb working the edge of her keys. The weight going foot to foot. The eyes running the same helpless circuit — me, the floor, the boxes, me — never able to stay off me for long. She had no practice being looked at and less at being caught wanting it, and every tell she owned was firing at once and she didn't know it.

I have spent my whole life among people trained to give nothing away. She gave away everything. It was the most human thing I'd stood near in years.

For a second neither of us moved. The rain ticked on the glass. Then I went to do the decent thing and get something on — and my clothes were in the open box on the floor, and she was planted dead in the only path to it, between me and the box, and she did not move.

I waited for her to. She couldn't. I read it clean off her: too far off her own axis to manage the single step aside, and aware of it, and being killed by it.

I could've asked her to move.

I didn't want to ask her to move.

I am not proud of this. I wanted the other thing — to find out what happened if I didn't.

So I came to her. Slow. Watching the whole way — the breath gone shallow, the pulse jumping visible in her throat, the eyes trying to leave me and failing. And my own body answered hers the way it hadn't answered anything in longer than I can name, low and hard and stupid, the oldest wiring there is, and I had to hold myself dead still around it. I crossed the last of the small room, past the polite distance, past the line her whole body had been holding, until I was close enough to feel the heat come off her.

I didn't touch her.

I reached past her — arm by her cheek, by her shoulder, near enough to feel the warmth off her skin without once landing on it — and my hand found the open box at her back and rested there. Taking nothing. Because getting to the box was never the point, and I think we both knew it, and for one suspended second I stayed exactly there, with her caught loose in the cage of my reach, neither of us breathing.

Then I drew back. Before the want in me could turn into a single thing she hadn't asked for. And I watched the cold come down over her, watched her drop back into herself all at once and step away so fast her shoulder cracked the frame.

And then she started building.

She didn't come further in. Bag where it fell, one hand on the frame, keys biting the other, she laid it down level, a line at a time. That room is yours. This one's mine. The bathroom we split, and you knock. Label your shelf. Hands off my food. The noise stops at ten.

"I signed a lease. I'll honour it. That doesn't make us anything."

And somewhere in the middle of the list, the play went out of me.

Because I heard what the flatness was doing. It wasn't a wall thrown up against a creep. It was the one cable holding her on her feet, and she was paying it out hand over hand, and if it snapped she went down. So I folded the big easy gravity down to the smallest, quietest shape a man my size can fold into, and I let her finish without putting a single word in.

"Okay," I said.

Just that. I took the wall out of her hands like something she'd carried a long way, and I meant it.

She turned for her room too fast for a floor she hadn't learned, and her foot found a box, and this time there was no frame —

and I had her before I'd decided to move.

Both arms. Her whole weight come down against me, her palms flat to my bare chest, my heart going like a snare under her right hand. For one second the world was rain and the warm of her and her face at my throat, and the want struck like a full chord and held —

and then I set her back on her own feet and stepped off. A clean pace. Turning as I went, because the one thing on this earth I wanted less than to let go of her was to be a thing she couldn't get away from.

"Sorry. Floor's wet. I dripped everywhere." Already reaching for a box. "Give me ten seconds."

I got a shirt. Got gone. Came back decent — the whole bare fact of me folded away into soft grey cotton, which is the only honest disguise I own.

She was already behind her door. I heard the bolt go over. Cheap brass, the one improvement she'd ever made to a place that was never hers to improve, thrown against me with a sound like a small no.

I deserved it. I went and sat on the floor of my room with my back to the shared wall.

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I called Hyun, because Hyun had to know the one thing that broke the whole arrangement.

"The tenant's a woman."

The particular Hyun silence. The one that means he's already three moves down the board and didn't like any of them. "...The lease says Yun Jae-wu."

"The lease is wrong, or the name is. She's a woman, Hyun. I'm sharing a wall with a woman."

"Then you're not." Flat, fast, the manager all the way up. "Give me the night. There's a serviced place in Hannam, no names on the door. I'll have the boxes moved before she wakes and the lease paid out — generously, a kindness, she'll think she won something. You were never there."

And there it was. The thing my world does.

I've watched it done. A problem made into a person, the person made into a payment, folded out of the night so smoothly she thanks you on her way through the door. Clean. Kind, even, if you squint. The responsible thing, the thing that keeps her name a full city's width from mine.

"No," I said.

I talked him down with the only argument that holds, which was that there was nothing to fix. Nobody alive had this address but him. I was a man renting a box room under a plain name; she was a woman who'd never heard of Seungwoo and owned no television to hear of him on. The truth was too stupid to be a scandal. Idol hides in spare room, nods at roommate over kettle. The danger had never been her.

The danger was the fix.

The real reason I kept, the one I couldn't make sound like sense out loud, I kept to myself: I was not going to be one more set of hands that made her disappear.

Hyun let it go. Within limits, the way he lets everything go. The line clicked dead, and the phone lit at once with the thing it had been doing all night.

Sun: hyung. blink twice if alive. sending a search party (it's just Reo, he was free) Reo: i'm not free i'm emotionally unavailable, there's a difference Tae: leave him be. the doctor said rest. that means rest, Sun — not "rest" with the producing files open at 4 a.m., which the studio app says SOMEBODY was doing. Yejun: album's not writing itself. somebody warn his throat the comeback already slid to spring. Reo: yejun i will bury you in the snow we don't have Sun: all of that — it's love, hyung. we love you. EAT SOMETHING.

I read it twice. Four men holding their entire careers in a stack on the strength of a record I couldn't get one true verse out of, and the only way any of them could say we're scared for you was in jokes, because the other way doesn't survive being typed.

The comeback slid to spring. That one's mine. Yejun isn't wrong — Yejun is never wrong, it's what makes him impossible to be in a room with and equally impossible to resent — and I typed nothing into the group, because anything I typed was either a lie or a worry, and I'm fine is both.

A separate message came in under the noise. Tae, alone, off the group.

you don't have to answer them. you answer me. are you okay. and — don't forget the SEORÉ fitting. your mother's office called me twice today. that one I can't get you out of.

So even here. Even now. The machine keeps one hook in you no matter how far you walk.

I sent back I'm okay. I'll be there. — one of which was true — and sat there holding the whole of my life in two hands. The comeback bleeding out for want of a song. Four men I'd die for, waiting. A fitting and a merger crouched behind it. An engagement dinner with a date already nailed to it. A thousand hours, not one of them mine.

All of it on this side of a phone screen.

And on the other side of six feet of bad plaster, a woman throwing a brass bolt against



me and counting herself to sleep.

I put the phone face-down.

The rain kept on at the window. Through the wall her radiator knocked twice and went quiet. My fingers had already started up against my knee without asking me — four and four and four, the old count, the rain-count — and for once I didn't make them stop. I let myself do the thing I won't do anywhere the machine can see me do it. I thought about her on purpose. The gold in the eyes. The flat brave voice laying down its line. The weight of her against my chest for one whole second.

And the song moved.

Not the fragment now. More of it. It came up under my ribs and ran, the rain folded through it, and for the first time in months it ran all the way toward an ending I could nearly hear — and stopped, gentle, one step short, at the exact place where she is and I'm not allowed to go.

My fingers went still.

Then they moved again, with purpose this time, because the vow doesn't care that it's two in the morning and there's a woman asleep six feet away. The vow only knows a bar has arrived and a bar uncaught is a bar lost. No paper I'd trust in reach. So I uncapped the pen with my teeth and wrote it on the back of my own hand — five quick strokes of a stave drawn freehand, the notes dropped onto it fast, and beside them, small, the only words that had come.

gold, no word.

Just that. Not whose gold. Not why a grown man would spend ink on the colour of an eye at two in the morning. The notes were safe; anyone could read them and find only music. The meaning I left off, the way I always leave it off, and I capped the pen and lay back down with my hand held a careful inch off the blanket so the ink wouldn't smear before I could copy it clean in the morning.

Still, I thought. The one thing I could never buy, and it was three feet away, bolting a door against me.

I should've been afraid. I was.

But under the fear, for the first time since a wet night three years ago put her in a room with me and then took her out of it again before I knew her name, there was a thing that wasn't fear at all.

She was here.

And I was going to be careful — more careful than I have ever been about anything in a life that has not, until now, given me a single thing worth being careful with — and I was not going to make her sorry the universe had been this careless with the both of us.